THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

If God Knows What You Will Do, Are You Free?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 8, Part 3

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 8 (final part), completing the Eight Chapters **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 21 May 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: three answers on Pharaoh

This class completed the Shemonah Perakim. The Rabbi reviewed Chapter 8 so far: people are born with propensities, not fixed natures; "everything is in the hands of heaven except the fear of heaven"; the laws of nature do not change. Then the three answers on the hardening of Pharaoh's heart:

- **The Rambam:** after centuries of oppression, Hashem took away Pharaoh's ability to do teshuvah, so that he would bear the consequences of what he had freely done.
- **The Ramban:** the open miracles would have forced his hand, so Hashem hardened his heart to restore a fair choice.
- **Ibn Ezra:** a person is led along the path he chooses; it became harder, but the choice remained.

Only on the Rambam's reading did Pharaoh have no choice left, which is why the Rambam explains that Moses kept asking in order to show the world that Hashem can sometimes withhold teshuvah.

A participant asked whether there is a tradition that Pharaoh did teshuvah in the end. The Rabbi said he had not come across it, and that in any case it would not fit the Rambam's approach, whose whole point is that Pharaoh bore the full consequences.

Sihon

The Rambam says the same applies to Sihon, king of Heshbon. At the end of the forty years, Israel asked to pass through his land, and the Torah says Hashem hardened his spirit so that he refused, and he was defeated in battle. The Rambam explains that Sihon too was being punished for earlier wrongs.

The Rabbi raised a difficulty. With Pharaoh the Torah describes the oppression at length. With Sihon there is no record of any earlier wrong; our first meeting with him is at his border. The Rambam has to assume he did something without a source. The Ramban's answer does not fit either, since Sihon saw no plagues. Ibn Ezra's approach works in both cases.

The prophets on withholding teshuvah

The Rambam brings more examples of Hashem closing the way back as a punishment for serious, deliberate sin:

- Isaiah: "Make the heart of this people fat, make their ears heavy, and shut their eyes... lest they return and be healed."
- Elijah: "You have turned their heart backwards."
- Hosea: "Ephraim is joined to idols; leave him alone." He became attached to them by his own will, so he is left to his path.

The Rambam is pleased with this explanation, calling it beautiful for those who understand fine matters.

There are also verses where prophets ask Hashem not to do this. Moses after the golden calf argued that the nations would say Hashem could not save His people. Isaiah asks, "Why, Hashem, do You make us stray from Your ways?", grieving over exile and the success of the nations. Malakhi records people saying "Where is the God of justice?" and "It is useless to serve God." In those cases the concern is hillul Hashem.

The conclusion: it is in your hands

The Rambam sums up: every person can choose good or bad. Except where Hashem withholds teshuvah as a punishment, acquiring good or bad character is entirely in our hands. Therefore we have a duty to work on ourselves, because no one else will do it for us. That is the meaning of the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot: "If I am not for myself, who will be for me?" The Rabbi: "no one is going to help you if you don't want to help yourself. That's what life's about."

The great question: foreknowledge and free will

The Rambam says this short introduction is not really the place for deep metaphysics, but he feels he cannot avoid it. If Hashem knows whether a person will be righteous or wicked, how is that person free? And if He does not know, His knowledge is incomplete. The Rabbi stressed that we cannot even consider that Hashem does not know the future. Both principles are fixed; the question is how they fit together.

He gave an example: lying in bed, deciding whether to snooze or get up for shaharit. Hashem knows how that deliberation will end. So what is the point of deliberating?

Suggestions from the class included parallel outcomes, and the idea that Hashem knows but does not interfere. The Rabbi then set out three classic approaches.

Rav Saadiah Gaon. Hashem knows what you will choose, but knowing does not cause it, like an observer watching from afar. The Rabbi's difficulty: if Hashem already knows every outcome, why must we live through it all? It would be a kind of simulation. One could answer that we need to experience it ourselves.

Ralbag (Gersonides). A 13th-century philosopher and mathematician. He says Hashem limits His own foreknowledge of our specific choices in order to give us freedom. The Rabbi finds this very hard. Just as Hashem cannot make a stone too heavy for Him to lift, or catch the flu, that is not a limitation but simply not what God is.

The Rambam's answer

The Rambam builds on two principles.

1. **Hashem and His knowledge are one.** A person and his knowledge are two things: you can have the person without the knowledge. With Hashem there are no separate parts. He is the knower, the known and the knowledge itself. That is why the Torah says "by the life of Pharaoh" or "by the life of your soul", but never "by the life of Hashem", only "as Hashem lives". The thirteen attributes of mercy are not thirteen parts of God but the ways we perceive Him. The Rabbi used the image of one sun seen through glasses of different colours, and warned against studying the sefirot as if they were parts of God.
2. **We cannot grasp Hashem's essence.** Not because of any lack in Him, but because of His perfection and our limits, as the eye cannot take in the full light of the sun.

Therefore: if we cannot know Hashem, we cannot know His knowledge, since they are the same thing. The question is real from our side, because we live in past, present and future and our knowledge is separate from ourselves. But Hashem's knowledge is of a different kind, and somehow within it He knows the future while we remain free. As Job is asked, "Can you find out the depth of God?" The Rambam says the same in Hilchot Teshuvah, citing "My thoughts are not your thoughts", and develops the unity of God and His knowledge in Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah.

Raavad and Tosafot Yom Tov

The Raavad objects in his glosses: why raise a question you cannot answer, and leave simple people with doubts? The Rabbi said the Raavad does not appreciate the depth of what the Rambam intended. The Tosafot Yom Tov (Rabbi Yom Tov Lipmann Heller of Krakow) defends the Rambam from the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot, chapter 3: "All is foreseen, and permission is given." The Mishnah states both truths and offers no reconciliation, because none is available to us. That is the Rambam's approach.

Discussion

A participant argued that the Rambam and Saadiah are really saying the same thing: God is outside time, as He is outside space, so for Him there is no "before". The Rabbi agreed that this is the depth of the Rambam, but still saw them as different: "One's giving an answer and one is saying you can't ask the question." Another participant found the simple view enough: God knows the end, but we do the choosing. The Rabbi's response: that is Saadiah's approach, and if it satisfies you, stick with it.

The Rambam closes: everything is in your hands, which is why the Torah commands and teaches; the rest of Hashem's ways are beyond us. Next week: a brief summary of all eight chapters, then the Rambam's commentary on Pirkei Avot.

Summary

- Sihon, like Pharaoh, is explained by the Rambam as punishment for earlier sins, though the Torah records none.

- The prophets show that Hashem sometimes withholds teshuvah from those who sinned deliberately and gravely.
- Character is in our own hands: "If I am not for myself, who will be for me?"
- On foreknowledge: Saadiah says knowing does not cause; Ralbag says God limits His knowledge; the Rambam says God's knowledge is one with Him and beyond our grasp.
- Tosafot Yom Tov finds the Rambam's view in "All is foreseen, and permission is given."

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/ME1t51G0ajI · More shiurim: rabbikada.com